

The Role of Chocolate in Maya Society and Ritual

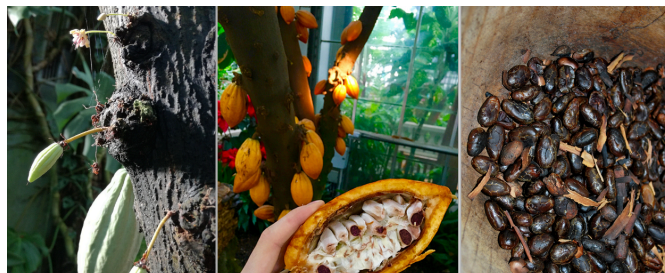


The Role of Chocolate in Maya Society and Ritual

Cacao, the plant from which **chocolate** is made, was used in a variety of ways in the societies of ancient Mesoamerica and South America, with cacao seeds traded as far north as the US Southwest. Cacao held a particularly meaningful role in Maya society, as you learned in the article by Keith Prufer and Jeffrey Hurst. Cacao was, of course, a food source, used in a highly valued beverage. Another key use of cacao was as currency, an indigenous medium of exchange used in several Mesoamerican societies. But the meaning of cacao went well beyond this utilitarian role, extending its application to ritual activities, including rites of passage between stages of life and also between life and death.

Cacao is the name used in several Mayan languages to refer to the tree *Theobroma cacao* and its seeds, as well as a beverage derived from those seeds.

Chocolate is a food made from fermented, roasted, ground cacao seeds. The addition of sugar and milk to cacao to make what we term “milk chocolate” is a European addition; neither cane sugar nor milk was available to the Maya or Aztecs.





A *Theobroma cacao* tree with unripe fruit (top), a ripe seed pod (middle), and fermented, roasted cacao seeds (bottom).

Source: Wikimedia Commons: [Tree](#)

(https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Cocoa_tree_blossom_and_fruit.jpg), [Seed Pod](#)

([https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Chocolate_in_its_Rawest_Form_\(27583224425\).jpg](https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Chocolate_in_its_Rawest_Form_(27583224425).jpg)), [Roasted Seeds](#)

(<https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:CacaoChonita14.JPG>)

The identification of cacao archaeologically has been challenging, as seeds are generally poorly preserved in archaeological contexts across Mesoamerica. A more effective method for tracing its use has been chemical-residue analysis, including the use of various forms of spectrometry as Prufer and Hurst used in the identification of the cacao seeds they found in the excavation they describe. Not only cacao seeds themselves can be analyzed, however; the ceramic vessels that were used to prepare and drink a chocolate beverage also contain traces of distinct chemical components of cacao. We also have iconographic depictions of cacao in both Maya and Aztec art that depict cacao fruits and cacao beverages. Seeing particular types of ceramic vessels in these iconographic depictions helps archaeologists to make inferences about their use; this is the basis on which the cup depicted below was identified as a cacao-drinking cup. It could be analyzed using residue analysis to confirm this use, but those analyses are destructive and so unlikely to be applied to such a well preserved, entire ceramic vessel.



Maya cacao-drinking vessel with an inscription reading "yuk'ib baje wa-KAAN TOOK' bakab," which means "the drinking cup of Baje Kaan Took, the ruler," who is depicted here on his cup (left); Maya mural depiction of a frothed cacao beverage (center); Aztec sculpture of a person carrying a cacao pod (right).

Source: [The Met Museum](#)

(<https://www.metmuseum.org/art/collection/search/316711>),

[Wikimedia Commons](#)

(https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Mayan_people_and_chocolate.jpg)

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(https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Aztec_Man_Carrying_a_Cacao_Pod_1440-1521.jpg)

Another source of knowledge about the role of cacao in ancient Maya society is ethnographic research on historical and contemporary Maya communities, such as that described by Prufer and Hurst in their article (pp. 284-290). These ethnographic accounts of cacao use by Maya communities help Prufer and Hurst to reconstruct the role of the five cacao seeds found in the burial of an individual in Bats'ub Cave that they detail in this article. Importantly, the role of cacao in the burial appears to have been twofold: It was a grave good for the deceased, meant to accompany them into the afterlife, but also a substance consumed by the living as part of funerary ceremonies to prepare and transport the deceased individual into the afterlife. The unique role of the deceased individual in life, possibly as a ritual specialist or shaman, is inferred from the funerary furniture placed with the deceased, the unique location of this burial in a cave, and the specific iconography of objects placed in the burial, based on ethnographic parallel and historical accounts. The presence of cacao in this person's burial draws attention to its specific role in ritual practice.